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ON THE PSYCHOLOGICAL ORIGINS OF DIVINE KINGSHIP

Paper read at the Society's Meeting, November 20, 1935

BY H. G. BAYNES

THE fact that a psychologist is invited by an anthropological society to contribute a paper for discussion is in itself a significant occurrence. It amounts almost to a confession that the necessity for scientific syncretism, by which both disciplines are impelled, is felt to be of greater moment than the difference of their respective postulates.

In anthropology we can point to the contributions of distinguished writers brought together in the two volumes *Myth and Ritual* and *The Labyrinth*; to the invaluable works of Prof. Hocart, e.g. *Kingship* and *The Lifegiving Myth*; to the works of Perry, Elliot Smith and others testifying to the vigorous syncretistic spirit in this discipline. The method consists in analysing a traditional pattern in such a way that inner correspondences are revealed between the elements of the given pattern and other forms in an analogous field of reference. Hocart's work, *Kingship*, is an excellent example of this method. Through a careful analysis of the rites of coronation, marriage, ordination, etc., in many cultures, he discovered a convincing series of correspondences with the primitive pattern of initiation; concluding therefrom that these were all cultural variants of a fundamental ritual pattern of initiation.

The existence of a basal or archetypal pattern from which a number of traditional rites have developed, presents us with a highly interesting and hence highly disputable problem; namely, do these cultural variants point to a world-

wide migration of ideas from a single cultural source, or have they developed autochthonously out of the relatively uniform basal structure of the psyche? Our preference for one or other side of this ancient debate depends, I believe, more on one's fundamental psychic disposition, or type, than upon the value of the evidence. The proof of autochthonous creation, it is true, must rest largely on the absence of the possibility of diffusion—a negative condition that is exceedingly hard to substantiate. But the autochthonists are not really interested in this type of evidence, a fact which by itself reveals the existence of a temperamental rather than a rational preference. The introverted thinker (a good autochthonist must surely have strong introverted sympathies) viewing things from the standpoint of the subject, realizes that vital forms of expression are created out of vital needs. He knows that the vital needs of human beings are relatively few and remarkably constant. If a visitor comes to his house who possesses a better technical equipment for expressing a vital human need than the one he has hitherto employed, he may or may not adopt the better technique. But never for a moment will he allow that the borrowed, or adapted, technique was anything more than a modification of his own original. Whereas the thorough-going extraverted diffusionist tends to assume that the presence of the more cultivated visitor in the house provides an adequate explanation for the need as well as for the equipment, as though invention were the mother of necessity.

The controversy continues to rage, because a rather specious loyalty to one's temperamental viewpoint urges one unconsciously to emphasize the arguments that favour one's own psychological predilection, and to depreciate those of the opposite type. Neither side can conclusively prove its case; since the autochthonists are faced with a bulk of irrefutable evidence for the historical fact of diffusion; while the diffusionists are bound to admit that the very fact

that certain specific cultural patterns have achieved a world-wide distribution points to the existence of a correspondingly universal vital need. Whether such a need creates a spontaneous cultural expression, or selects its form from a visiting culture is not a matter of very great concern for the psychologist. It is different for the anthropologist. In his attempt to trace the successive migrations of early cultures, the distribution of identical forms is highly significant. But, for the psychologist who is concerned more with establishing the basal uniformity of the human psyche, the influence of cultural diffusion assumes a secondary rôle.

Jung's theory of the basic uniformity of the psychical structure is grounded on the fact that a comparison of the mythic patterns gathered from every part of the globe reveals a very high degree of uniformity of structure. When we reflect upon the great differences of climatic and vegetational conditions, from the arctic to the equator, to which mankind is adapted, the relative uniformity of man's physical structure is a surprising fact. The uniformity of cerebral structure is such, that it requires a skilled eye to detect the differences between the brain of an Australian aboriginal and that of a Harley Street specialist. In respect to the physical structure of man we can, therefore, speak of an archetype, in so far as a high degree of consistency is maintained under a great variety of conditions.¹ In as much as the psyche is nothing else than the response of conscious human existence to the conditions of life on this planet, it would be surprising indeed if its basal structure did not bear witness to such a uniformity as we find in the human body. But when we speak of the basal psychic structure it must not be supposed that we assume identity between psyche and brain. We cannot even say that the

¹ In comparative anatomy the term archetype signifies "an assumed ideal pattern of the fundamental structure of each great division of organized beings" (*Oxford Dictionary*).

psyche is the function of the brain : we do not know. All we can know of the nature of the basal psyche is from its products, particularly from spontaneous natural products such as dreams, myths, visions, etc., not to mention that vast store of legendary material which Sir James Frazer has brought together within the pages of *The Golden Bough*. By sifting and collating this material we find, just as Hocart discovered in his research into the ritual connexions of kingship, that certain *leit-motifs*, certain basic images and patterns, reveal themselves as the elementary components of which the almost infinite variety of mythological forms is composed. These basic structural elements Jung has called archetypes or primordial images. He regards them as emotionally-toned psychic entities which have been developed in the general psychic structure through the endlessly repeated occurrence of certain typical needs, relationships and adaptations in the totality of human experience. Thus, just as the structure of the heart bears witness to the immense variety of strains which human enterprise has imposed upon it through untold ages ; so, in precisely similar fashion, the basic psyche carries the record of man's instinctive adaptation in the form of these collective images.

For this evening's discussion I have selected the archetype of the king ; and I propose to enquire into the psychic origins of the king-idea from the standpoint of racial experience. According to Elliot Smith's account in his valuable work, *Human History*, there are certain indigenous tribes, as, for instance, the Eskimos ; certain tribes of North American Indians ; the Punan of Borneo ; the Bushmen of Africa ; food-gathering peoples living on the outskirts of civilization, who have no idea of the king as an hierarchical figure. These people live in small communities in a state of natural communism. Produce of the hunt is shared ; women have as a rule equal rights with men, and the leader, or head-man, is merely the man of ripest ex-

perience. He possesses no magical qualities. There is no hierarchy of power, because social organization has never become a problem. These people still preserve a natural human piety, and appear to reject the proffered boons of civilization as something dangerous, if not actually impious. To maintain the integrity of their natural condition is their one guiding principle. Nature is their wisdom and their safeguard, and they refuse to improve upon what she provides, or to build up civilized ramparts from which to defy her wrath.

If we compare this picture, which is vouched for by a variety of competent observers, with the collectivized races who, by the practice of agriculture and other cultural inventions, gradually erected a counter-position of civilized security over against the original mother-deity, we can readily grasp how the need of a protected, hence rapidly growing, population for an infallible safeguard from the devouring and ruthless aspect of nature came to be invested in a magical or divine personality. There would necessarily devolve upon this being the function of fertility and security that had been previously guaranteed by the state of unity with nature. When we study the myths of early civilizing races we cannot but be impressed by an inescapable feeling of dread of this vengeful, destroying aspect of nature. We might almost suppose from this evidence that civilized man is burdened by a bad conscience in relation to his original animal state.

In the Gilgamesh epic, dating from early Sumerian civilization, we are the fortunate possessors of invaluable-psychological evidence of the hybris-guilt which accompanied every encroachment of early civilizing man upon the hitherto unchallenged primacy of nature. Gilgamesh is the cultural hero-king, two-thirds divine and one-third mortal, who tyrannically forces the people of Erech to incessant and arduous toil in the building of his city. In his attempt to

erect an impregnable counter-position over against the seductions of the primordial natural existence Gilgamish violates every natural relationship.

Gilgamish leaveth no son to his father. . . .

Gilgamish leaveth no maid to her mother, nor daughter to hero, Nay, nor a spouse to her husband.

In opposition to the original instinctive pattern of the natural community Gilgamish has set up an artificial cultural pattern in which all loyalty and allegiance is centred in the king. In other words, the civilizing genius of man has revolted against the original submission to nature and her laws ; laws that are written in the unconscious inheritance of instinct. In place of his original allegiance man is seized by an idea forcing him to some unknown destination ; an idea of such immeasurable power that it could only have been fathered by the sun. This belief is asserted in the divine nature of Gilgamish and in the fact that Shamash, the sun-god, is mentioned as his father.

Like Zarathustra, Gilgamish manifests the one divine attribute of man, namely, the power to transcend himself and thus to create the beyond-man. But prophetic ideas are tyrannical. Accordingly Gilgamish, who personifies the civilizing idea, becomes a dictator, attempting to displace every former allegiance, in order to make his rule absolute. The civilizing genius of mankind has thrown up innumerable dictators who have, likewise, attempted this wholesale displacement of pre-existing natural loyalties, only to find their rule eventually undermined by the same underground secession of collective *libido* to the older gods, as is portrayed in this myth. This recession of the *libido* is represented by the prayers of the people of Erech ascending to Anu, imploring him to raise up a champion in their defence. He calls to Aruru ² :

² Citations are from R. Campbell Thompson's translation, *The Epic of Gilgamish* (Luzac and Co.).

“ ‘Twas thou, O Aruru, madest primeval seed of mankind,
 Do now make its fellow, so that he happen on Gilgamesh,
 Yea, in the day of his pleasure, so that they strive with each
 other,
 And he unto Erech give surcease.”

Out of the clay Aruru created Enkidu, a being who accords with the primordial image of the natural man.

“ Sprouted luxuriant growth of his hair like the awns of the barley,
 Nor knew he people nor land; he was clad in a garb like Sumuqan.
 E'en with the gazelles did he pasture on herbage, along with the cattle
 Drank he his fill, with the beasts did his heart delight at the water.”

Gilgamesh has a dream foretelling the advent of this champion of nature, and thereupon sends to the drinking place, where Enkidu comes with the wild animals to drink, a hunter accompanied by a courtesan of Ishtar's temple. The woman seduces him from his original virginal state, and when, finally, he realizes that the animals no longer accept him as one of themselves he follows the girl to Erech. The renegade recession of *libido* back to the primitive state would imply a complete rejection of the whole civilizing experiment. But even in the harshest moments of the Taurian age this was no longer possible. Mankind is irredeemably committed to the civilizing experiment, even though it destroy him. Therefore Enkidu cannot stay in the absolute primitive state. The true indigenous, food-gathering primitive is hardly seducible and cannot be enslaved, for he is still simple and whole. But Enkidu is a product of resistance. He is composed of opposite elements. Ninurta the warrior, Sumuqan the agriculturist. Cain and Abel, the first protagonists of the problem of the opposites in civilizing man, have entered into his composition.

Therefore, is he seducible. The rôle of the courtesan is as old as civilization; but assuredly not older. She is the snare to catch the renegade impulse in man. It is notorious that the courtesan's clientele consists mainly of married men. That is to say, men who have subscribed to the civilized pattern which entails allegiance to the civilizing goal. The renegade impulse as such stands in contradiction to this pattern. But since both cannot be lived at the same time the renegade is trapped in a mean and unconvincing compromise. Therefore is the courtesan dishonoured. She offers no solution to the conflict, but merely provides expression for a pathetic gesture of regret for a state that can never be recaptured.

The courtesan of Erech reminds Enkidu of the power and luxuriance, the heroic splendours of the city of Erech, and he has to follow her. Gilgamesh and Enkidu fight for the possession of the woman, and after a terrific encounter, in which Gilgamesh appears to get the better of his adversary, a mutual pact of brotherhood is sealed. From the moment this pact is made energy is released, and a new attempt at extending civilized lordship over nature immediately begins to revolve in the mind of Gilgamesh. He proposes an enterprise against Humbaba, the fearful monster who guards the Forest of Cedars. There are certain points concerning this enterprise about which the myth is quite definite. First, when Enkidu tries to dissuade his friend from pitting his power against that of an elemental daemon—"Humbaba, his roar was a whirlwind. Flame in his jaws, and his very breath Death"—Gilgamesh replies with matter-of-fact precision: "'Tis that I need the rich yield of its mountains I go to the Forest." We are actually living in a historical moment when the modern representative of Gilgamesh gives the self-same reply. The second clear statement of the myth is that the Forest of Cedars enfolds the sacred precincts of Ishtar the nature-goddess.

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“Eke they beheld the Mount of the Cedar, the home of the Immortals,
 Shrine of Irnini³ the Cedar uplifting its pride 'gainst the mountain.”

Thus we can infer that the monster Humbaba is again a projection of the abysmal dread that accompanied every new advance of the civilizing rebellious son against the domain of the original mother-goddess.

If we regard this myth as a collective human document—and how else are we to understand a myth?—we see that the characteristic opposition of the civilized mind between instinct and culture was already a formidable problem in the third millennium before Christ. Gilgamesh personifies the power of the cultural idea. Enkidu that of the primordial unconscious. As the one urges forward the other pulls back. Enkidu, representing the standpoint of the primitive soul, is won over to the civilizing idea only when the validity of his standpoint is given due tribute. But the pact of brotherhood has something of coercion in it, since Gilgamesh always holds the whip-hand and Enkidu is never completely convinced. He seems to have much the same reserve and foreboding in respect to Gilgamesh's grandiose schemes as the indigenous food-gatherers (according to Elliot Smith's account) manifest towards the proffered boons of civilization.

When we identify ourselves wholly with the magnificence and power of our civilizing mission, we always tend to do violence to our basal primitive nature. The bombing of Abyssinian villages by Italian aeroplanes fills us with intense anger and shame because we too are involved. There is a million-year-old human being who lives in us, who shares like Enkidu in the fundamental virtue of the animal state and in whose eyes the civilizing hero, who knows neither ruth nor fear, and who disowns the original law of reci-

³ A form of Ishtar.

procity, is a rebel and a criminal. But just because the civilizing hero, at every bound, oversteps nature's law of reciprocity he is tormented by a bad conscience with regard to nature. Hence the crime of hybris has always been followed by compulsive expiation. So in the end Gilgamesh, the hero, becomes Gilgamesh the victim. The death of Enkidu is a direct result of heroic hybris, in other words, the arrogant defiance of the gods. The loss of Enkidu means the loss of the guarantee and support of the basic instinctual energy. Gilgamesh becomes a restless, driven creature, like Orestes pursued by the furies, eternally tormented by the longing for immortality which had been previously guaranteed by the instinctive covenant with nature.

Throughout mythology we find the hero who attempts the impossible inseparably joined to his compensatory figure ; namely, the helpless victim of fate. We need only mention the tragic fate of Prometheus ; the humiliation of Heracles, bound to serve Omphale the luxuriant Queen in a menial capacity as penance for his crime ; the fall of Icarus ; the betrayal of Siegfried ; the killing and dismemberment of Osiris ; the betrayal and crucifixion of Christ. The traditional killing of the king, which later developed into the sacrifice of criminals and other human victims in place of the king ; the ceremonies of public humiliation of the king, an example of which was given in *Myth and Ritual* ; all these examples, which can be multiplied indefinitely from the pages of *The Golden Bough*, point to the same fundamental psychic conflict that has obsessed man since his first faltering steps along the path that estranged him from his original unconscious unity with nature.

Moreover, this intimate connexion, amounting almost to identity, between the hero and the victim is not merely an archaeological curiosity. It is an inescapable condition of our actual psychic economy. Examples will be familiar to everyone, of the individual in whom one function attains

heroic status, or is exalted by an heroic aim, while its opposite function lies prone and passive as a helpless victim of circumstance. What woman does not know the man who fills the hero rôle in the disciplined realm of the intellect, but feels himself doomed to be a scapegoat in the opposite realm of feeling? In certain affective conditions in both men and women we can observe the manic, exalted mood of the hero followed directly by the depressive, impotent mood of the victim. This ambivalence of mood is symbolized in the mythic figure of the hero, who always has a vulnerable spot where the lurking traitor can plunge his spear, or the venom of the snake can find an entry. Thus every hero is eventually betrayed by his opposite principle; a fatality which brings us back once more to the fundamental conflict of the civilized mind; namely, the heroic, tyrannical idea, which aims at perfection, warring against the primitive unconscious, which still clings to the primordial, instinctual simplicity of life. Thus the history of civilization should be written from opposite standpoints, from the angle of the slave as well as of the ruler, from the psychology of the renegade and scapegoat, of the two million witches burnt in a single century in Europe, of the tortured suspect, of the victims impaled for the sake of an absolute truth, of the lunatics, criminals and neurotics, as well as from that of the law-giver and law-abider. Viewing history from this angle, it would seem that the cruelty and ruthlessness of the tyrant spring from the sense of guilt and insecurity by which the civilizing experiment has been burdened since its first beginnings.

For the tyrant is never a mere solitary individual lusting for power. He is also the voice of a vast animal, afraid of its own double nature. Is not Gilgamesh described "He is the shepherd of Erech, the high-wall'd. He is their shepherd . . . masterful, dominant, subtle"? Mankind is also a herd, an irresistible collective momentum, a streaming of vital

units demanding a leader, in whom the prestige and power of man, the successful gregarious animal, can become manifest. Thus, at bottom, the great shepherds of mankind, from Gilgamesh to Hitler, are mediums of a vast collective force or tendency which they can neither control nor understand, even though they become its voice. They are possessed by it, and are usually destroyed by it. Collectively mankind has a quite different psychology from that of any of its individual units. Mothers and fathers never want to cast their children into the flaming belly of a demon-god. The individual African negro would never dream of inflicting the cruelties and mutilations which the youths and maidens have to undergo in their tribal initiations. The holocaust of victims offered up to tribal deities, or slain to accompany the spirit of the dead king, are terrifying and unintelligible facts to every individual heart and head. And no man has ever been able to say why these things are done ; just as no man in Italy today can provide any convincing reason for the slaughter of the people of Abyssinia.

When I was with Jung in his expedition to East Africa in 1926, we frequently asked *laibons* and head-men to tell us why they had to subject their youths to such frightful ordeals in their puberty initiations. The only reply they could offer was, "If we did not do these things, they would be no better than the animals."

This reply is a good example of what Lévy Brühl has termed "*representation collective*"; namely, something which everyone believes, but no one thinks. It is not thought ; it is merely said. And just because it is a collective representation it brings us, in my view, quite near to the solution of the problem. If we had the power to evoke this evening the spirits of the most abominable tyrants in human history, and could compel them to answer for their worst deeds before the tribunal of our individual feeling, would they not all say as with a single voice, "If we had not

done these things, then this or that worse consequence would have followed"? They would all instinctively claim the necessity of prophylactic bloodshed—against what? Are not the magical offices of the king-sacrificer also at bottom a prophylactic measure against this same menace?

Once in a confidential undertone my professor of Zoology at Cambridge said to me, with the hope perhaps of discouraging my uneducated importunity: "Young man, if you want to be popular among your fellow-men, ask no questions which cannot be answered." You see now where my intemperate mind has led me; into the dark underworld of the human unconscious. Perhaps I should have done better to listen to his counsel! But occasionally it happens that questions which seem altogether beyond the rational scope of isolated, individual consciousness are solved in an irrational way by a vision, or dream from the collective unconscious. I should like to describe to you a dream which came to me after a long discussion I had had with Professor MacDougall in Switzerland. We had spent a Sunday on the Rigi, and the problem of the collective psyche had been uppermost in our discussion, since it was a matter about which we found the utmost difficulty in arriving at any agreed conception.

Two nights later I dreamed that I was on the slopes of a mountain and was pointing out to my companion how a great spur of the mountain resembled the shape of a vast animal. As I watched I saw that it actually was an incredibly huge beast, for, looking carefully, I observed the slow heaving of its flanks. It seemed to be embedded in, and almost of the same nature as, the mountain itself. The jaws of the creature were like a triangular pit at the other end, a mile or so away from where we were standing. Three robed figures stood in a triangular disposition about the yawning mouth. A high barricade, or screen, was erected to the left of this sacred enclosure, and I saw on the horizon a great hurrying

stream of human figures, like a stream of ants, moving towards the barricade. Again like ants they clambered over the barricade; and as they dropped to the ground on the other side, they were picked up by the priests and thrown into the monster's mouth.

I could not conceivably explain such a dream as representing an aspect of my personal psychology. Twice, it is true, I have witnessed hordes of men and women streaming in a demoralized rabble without aim or consciousness, and doubtless such experiences make an unforgettable psychic impression. Moreover, I have observed that collective migration of animals, also insects, as well as those of man, are usually attended by a reckless, regardless spirit that is frequently suicidal. In particular I might mention the migration westwards of the lemmings in Norway, which ends in their being drowned in the sea.

We have absolutely no means of knowing how these incalculable collective motivations originate. We only see effects which we, rather blindly, ascribe to instinct. But the term instinct is also used to explain the orderly and discreet behaviour of these same creatures when they are adapted to their specific environment and manifest therein a totally different individual character from their migratory recklessness.

The contrast in behaviour between creatures adapted individually to their natural *milieu* and the same creatures under a collective motivation, whether of panic or any other mass-urge, is so striking that we are justified in concluding that the one state is safeguarded by an instinctive state of awareness, while the other is conditioned purely by the state of collective participation which is without safeguards.

So far as I am able to understand my dream at all, I regard it as a graphic representation of mankind in this state of collective unconsciousness in which individual awareness and responsibility are submerged by a mass-urgency that is

symbolized by a vast, archaic, devouring beast without heart or head. Our own experience shows us with what slow and arduous pains a relative detachment of individual consciousness is at last achieved from the original matrix of unconscious participation. In primitive societies individual consciousness rarely goes beyond a certain degree of personal awareness. The collectivized savage cannot be said to have any individual standpoint of thought or feeling, though naturally he has the instinctual awareness of a separate creature.

Is it possible now to relate these somewhat random reflexions about the collective psychology of mankind as a gregarious animal to the function and nature of the king? First let us ask the question: why is the king almost universally conceived as divine? Everyone knows the king to be a man with precisely the same body, the same human needs and limitations as all other mortals. He is born, he eats and sleeps and weds, grows old, and dies like other men; and yet, in so far as he is identified with the idea or image of kingship, he is without question divine. Before he was king, he had no special divinity. But from the moment the image clothes him he is immortal. No rational explanation which depends upon the fact that he has to perform ritual and executive functions vital to tribal welfare will really suffice. The Governor of the Bank of England, or the Prime Minister has equally vital functions to perform, but these persons have never been regarded as in any way divine.

No, we have to seek the answer to the riddle in the significant fact, so well elaborated by Hocart in his work, *Kingship*, that the ritual of coronation is at bottom identical with that of initiation.

The psychology of initiation is a vast subject. It would, therefore, be vain to launch our craft on that relatively uncharted sea. But this much we can say without fear of contradiction, initiation is always a *rite de passage*. It is

a birth-defile through which the raw human product is passed in order to emerge a neophyte. The neophyte is, as you know, instructed that his old self, or previous state, is dead and that he is now an entirely new creature. In many cases he is smeared with white clay, and has to be taught how to speak and eat and wash himself, as though he had actually not existed before.

You will remember what the head-man told us in Africa. "If they do not go through these things they are no better than animals." To a white man this answer would immediately be interpreted as an assertion of human superiority over the animal kingdom. This is precisely not what the African feels. He would not dream of putting man at the top of the animal hierarchy. Those animals he kills, he puts below him, but those that are able to kill him he sets above him. It is not, then, the arrogance of human power that prompts the above reply, but rather the deep collective fear of the animal state; namely, that state of frenzied possession by unconscious daemonic forces when all safeguards are abandoned. Again this has to be qualified, since the animals have their own instinctive awareness as safeguard, and this the African knows perfectly well. It is rather the state in which a man goes off by himself, listens to the bad spirits, becomes a renegade, goes back on the tribal solidarity, gets fascinated or bewitched. That which threatens collectivized mankind is the force which breaks the human ranks and drives men back to the wild, undisciplined state of a rogue elephant. This atavistic mood is dangerous not only to the individual; inasmuch as these daemonic states are highly contagious. Panic may start like a fire at a definite spot, but it easily becomes a conflagration. It is this fact which proves that these irrational affective states, although apparently localized in the individual psyche, are actually collective in character and origin. The collectivized man who breaks away and

goes back to the solitary reptilian level, where no loyalties, or allegiances, or obligations have power to hold him, is, of course, incomparably more dangerous than, and vastly inferior to, a wild animal. Moreover, the animals will no more accept kinship with the human renegade than the proud savage will accept the white man "gone native" as his equal. We often say of the degenerate white that he is no better than a savage. But what we mean is that he is incomparably more degraded. He cannot be a true savage; he is essentially a counterfeit, a renegade without safeguards.

These distinctions are psychologically of vital importance for the understanding of our problem, since it is clear that the danger which the initiation rite is directed against is the sinister lure of the retrograde path. There are only two paths for the *libido* to follow; either it goes onwards through its various phases and transformations, or backwards through a retrogressive evolution. The one we call evolution, the other atavism. Thus the rite of initiation into manhood is a forced introversion, a psychological histolysis, that is precisely analogous to the histolysis of the pupal state in which the organism of the caterpillar is transformed into that of the butterfly. It involves a kind of mitigated frenzy and insanity, whereby the lad is inoculated with the dread of the spirit world, with panic, with the fear of death, in fact with the terrible destructive aspect of the collective unconscious, but under safeguards. He is, as it were, passed by the priests, who represent traditional wisdom and tribal authority, into the very jaws of the great spirit monster. But even in the worst moments of fear, he is safeguarded. He can face the Minotaur just because he has in his hand a silken cord. This cord is the authority and continuity of tribal tradition. He is covered by the human pact. Thus, at the same moment that the lad is detached from the safeguard of the parents, he is inoculated against the worst dangers which beset human consciousness,

namely, the danger of being sucked back along the retrograde pathway by the fascination of the archaic images of the collective unconscious. Initiation, then, from the psychological angle is an indispensable prophylactic measure against the lure of atavism ; and we can surely ascribe the sinister increase in mental disorders throughout all classes in our civilized western communities to the decay of the traditional form of religious initiation and to the absence of any other cultural form which could take its place.

We are now in a position to appreciate how the idea of kingship necessarily became identified with that of divinity, which also includes the attribute of immortality. The king-idea is the silken thread. The safeguarding power of the continuity of tribal authority and tradition from earliest times is concentrated by means of mass-projection upon the person of the king. The distant heroic ancestors, the mighty figures of the mythic past are alive and present in the person of the king. He is the master symbol just because he is living history. The stability and continuity of the warm-blooded human pact, upon which the whole moral of the race depends, is present in the king as a living fact. Therefore allegiance to the king always means submission to the pact : and what is this pact but the means by which man, as a relatively weak and defenceless creature in the order of nature, is able to maintain a biological status, which otherwise he could never achieve ?

Thus we see that fundamentally the function of the king is religious in character. He is the integrating focus of authority and power, the spiritual talisman against the daemonic fascination of the collective unconscious, or world of the spirits. He is the defender of the faith *par excellence*, and since he is the symbol of the continuity of tribal life, he is also, necessarily, immortal. Let me read the opening lines of the Gilgamesh epic, which describes the essence of the king-idea as man conceived it in the dawn of civilization:

“ He who the heart of all matters hath proven let him lead the nation,
 He who all knowledge possesseth, therein shall he school the people,
 He shall his wisdom impart, and so shall they share it together.
 Gilgamish—he was the Master of wisdom, with knowledge of all things,
 He ’twas discovered the secret concealed . . .
 Aye handed down the tradition relating to things prediluvian.
 He is our shepherd—masterful, dominant, subtle.”

Hocart corroborates this same conception of the king-value where he points out that the king-sacrificer recreated the earth by the same methods⁴ as were used by the original creator. The ritual he employs is the traditional way, and the king-sacrificer is the one person empowered to enact it. The ritual, then, is the silken cord of continuity connecting the living tribe with its original source. It symbolizes a tribal memory of the victorious human pact, upon which their whole existence depends.

Here I should like to quote from Hocart a Brahmanic myth-ritual which affords highly suggestive testimony to this psychological value of the king, which we are attempting to reconstruct. The myth runs as follows: “ The gods and titans strove together for these worlds. They strove for the eastern quarter. The titans beat them thence.” And so they went fighting round the compass until “ they strove for the north-eastern quarter ; they were not beaten thence. This quarter is the unconquerable . . .” The gods said, “ through our lack of a king they beat us ; let us make a king.” They made Soma king. With Soma as king they conquered all the quarters. He who sacrifices has Soma as king. They place Soma on the cart as it stands facing east ; he conquers the east. They carry him round by the south ; thereby he conquers the southern quarter,” and so on round the com-

⁴ The Life-giving Myth in *The Labyrinth*, edited by S. H. Hooke, M.A., B.D. (S.P.C.K. London):

pass. The conclusion is, "By Soma, the king, he conquers all the quarters who knows this."

This myth tells us a great deal if we can attune our minds to the universal language of the myth. The titans are relatively familiar figures. We know from analogy with Greek mythology that they represent *daimones*, namely, vague personifications of elemental powers. In his excellent work, *From Religion to Philosophy*, Professor Cornford demonstrates the evolution of the elementary *daimones* of primitive Greek thought to the fully anthropomorphized figures of gods and heroes. There was a *daimon* of fire, of the gens, of mystical fraternities, of the sea, the wind. They are, in fact, the elementary psychic response to certain overwhelming, or dynamic impressions. The titans are vast, because they are overwhelming. Therefore, to the loosely-organized, relatively primitive mentality anything which could produce an overwhelming effect, either for man's good, or for his destruction, was conceived as divine or daemonic in character. Let me give you an example from my own observation. When camping on the slopes of Mt. Elgon in Kenya, we were living among the Elgonyi, a people closely related to the Masai. We observed them at sunrise prostrating themselves to the sun. Before doing so they breathed or spat on their hands and then, extending the palms towards the sun, exclaimed *Adhista*, which means Lord. The new moon was greeted in the same fashion and the word *Adhista* was also uttered. When at last these people came to trust us, they explained that only when the sun first leaps over the horizon is it *Adhista*. When it is high in the heavens it is no longer *mungu*. It was the first appearance of the sun and the new moon that meant god. Similarly in their description of *Ayik*, the evil power. He was not the origin of pestilence and catastrophes, or evil events. They disliked to speak of him. They described him as the bat's wing that strikes your face in a dark

cave. Or, making a low whistling sound, they said he was the cold wind that comes out of the graves and runs up your spine, when no one is near. When they dramatized *Ayik*, their teeth chattered with terror. It became perfectly clear that, for these people, god and devil were psychological moments. God was not the sun, but rather the moment of recreated moral, when the light and warmth of the sun banishes the fearful denizens of the night. And *Ayik* was the moment of panic, when the spirit is congealed and a man is spell-bound, overwhelmed, dismembered by blind terror.

Obviously these conceptions of the Elgoni are identical with Horus and Set of the Egyptians. It seemed to us more than probable that there, in the depths of Africa, we had stumbled upon the original religious experience. To the primitive mentality autonomous psychical events form the primary condition of life. The primitive has no trained, reliable, detached, intellectual function which can be relied upon to operate satisfactorily irrespective of the underlying subjective emotional state. He is literally at the mercy of psychic forces and, therefore, those things which can re-establish and evoke moral belong to the category divine; while those forces or conditions which overwhelm or undermine his moral are simply the devil.

The battle, then, between gods and titans symbolizes the struggle between opposing *libido* tendencies; the gods representing the inherited psychic elements that are experienced as helpful powers, while the titans represent aspects of nature which have the power of forcing a man into renegade panic or frenzy. In the battle the overwhelming power of the titans drives the gods backwards until the last barricade is reached. The eastern quarter was the first to be vanquished; therefore, the north-eastern sector would represent the last stand. This is when the real mettle of a man or a creature comes into action, and it is at this point that the divine symbol is evoked. A superior power is

needed to vanquish and transform the daemonic in man. Thus the myth shows us with clear precision that the king-idea was born, like the divine sword, *Nothung*, out of utter need.

In this connexion I should mention an interesting parallel mentioned by Richard Wilhelm, the eminent German sinologue. He said that the north-eastern point of the compass is regarded by the classical Chinese diviners as the favourable spot where new beginnings originate. It represents the dawn-point, or the point of the new moon ; hence it is identical in meaning with *Adhista* of the Elgoni, or Horus of the Egyptians.

The myth not only tells us of the primitive psychic necessity from which the king-idea sprang ; it also tells us the name and character of the first king. Soma, as you know, was a plant, from which an exceedingly powerful spirit was distilled. It was the juice which inspired mortals and was also the nectar of the gods. It is identified with the sap of trees and the seminal fluid. It is said that when Indra in the form of a falcon, stole the soma drink, the herdsman, Kriṣṇanu, wounded him in his foot with an arrow. Thus soma is equated with the fire stolen from the gods by Prometheus. Soma was the *φάρμακον ἀθανασίας* the stimulating wine, the holy drink of inspiration, the mead of immortality. Soma is also identified with Agni—fire in Hindu literature. When men drink it

“ They feel the god within their veins
And cry in loud exulting strains ;
We’ve quaffed the Soma bright
And are immortal grown ;
We’ve entered into light,
And all the gods have known.
What mortal now can harm,
Or foeman vex us more ?
Through thee beyond alarm,
Immortal god, we soar.” ⁵

⁵ Muir’s Original Sanskrit Texts.

Certain gnostic communities drank soma in their feast of communion, holding the same belief that when the exaltation of the soma drink possessed them they participated in divinity.

When we combine all these attributes, fire, fertility, the sap of life, immortality, divinity, inspiration, we see at once that soma is a *libido*-symbol of incalculable efficacy. These attributes can only mean that under the influence of the soma drink, men experienced the fullest possible enhancement of vigour and spiritual power.

But how cool these words sound and, therefore, how far away from that original divine frenzy which seized hold of the worshippers ! We have no introspective means by which we can recapture this central religious experience, though the dynamic idea which informed it we know without the shadow of a doubt. It was identification with or partaking of divinity. The fullness of godhood was known to man, not because theology was taught him by the priests, but because he actually experienced it. Let us not wince at this intoxicated experience of divinity. We think of alcohol as a chemical substance which, when administered in sufficient quantity, produces certain specific effects. This is a good example of how hard it is for the unaided reason to know the kingdom of heaven. If we have never once permitted our individual particularity, our detached personality to dissolve in the golden tremors of a wine-lit feast, we cannot know what mysteries are concealed behind the word intoxication. No man can reach that state by himself. Wine is the god of communion. It is essentially the maker and renewer of the human pact. Dionysos never revealed himself to the secret drinker, or to the dipsomaniac. The antique world had a truly moral attitude to the most intense sensory experiences. They valued self-discipline as we do ; but they gave the highest possible honour to those symbols which had the power of releasing instinctual energy as

though under divine aegis. The significance of the communion ritual as a *unio mystica* with god is at bottom sexual and very corporeal. Jung writes in his *Psychology of the Unconscious*: "The primitive significance of the communion is that of a *Hierosgamos*. Therefore, in the fragment of the Attis mysteries handed down by Firmicus, it is said that the mystic eats from the tympanon, drinks from the kymbalon, and he confesses, ὑπο τον παστόν ὑπέδουν which means, 'I have entered the bridal chamber'... Irenaeus mentions some more of the initiatory customs of certain gnostic sects, which were undoubtedly nothing but spiritual weddings."

This concrete honouring of the *libido* is found also in the Shakti ritual of communion, where the worshipper partakes of the five elements, grain, meat, fish, wine and woman. The essential idea of this communion feast is that the goddess Shakti, being the latent primordial energy of nature, manifests herself in these ritual elements and, therefore, in the moment of participation, the worshipper not only partakes of, or has union with divinity, but also, in so doing, he offers the goddess a moment of completion, or self-realization. But Shakti, as you know, is by no means a merely benign deity. She is also the devourer, the destroyer, the terrible one. She is as much daemonic as she is divine.

From these somewhat discursive reflections we can rejoin our discussion of Soma as king. We came to the conclusion, you will remember, that the titans represent the daemonic powers of the primitive unconscious, which very nearly overwhelmed and disrupted early civilizing communities. But where does the daemonic archaic power of the unconscious chiefly lurk but in just those overwhelming psychic tendencies we call animal instincts? When we discuss sexuality we enter the realm of daemonology, and our rational weights and measures become quite ineffectual. Everyone who has had experience of those tragic lives in

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which sexuality or alcoholism has assumed an archaic, or, as doctors express it, pathological character knows only too well the meaning of the term daemonic possession. Continuity of personality is broken, and in place of the known, and perhaps loved, individuality, a strange and devilish being inhabits the house of consciousness. This is the renegade, the betrayer of the human pact. When this daemonic complex is uppermost, one can believe nothing. There is no dependable self present, and, therefore, no undertaking will be carried out. An archaic spirit of uncontrollable power and urgency has taken possession, and if it gets too deep a hold in the psychic economy, the retrograde path to lunacy or suicide becomes more or less sure.

It is this fascination or possession by the archaism of the unconscious which has constantly threatened the integrity of the human society, whether savage or civilized. The threat is not that someone gets excited, or inspired, or begins to talk in strange tongues ; but always and only because of the deep renegade tendency stealthily to withdraw from the human pact, and to go off with the devil. The man who broods and glowers in a mood of hostile isolation, and will not say what is in his mind, is committing emotional blackmail : inasmuch as by arousing the primeval dread in those around him, he compels them either to placate him, or to have him certified. Whereas the man who is gripped by a terrible mood, but none the less communicates the fact to his wife, or to his friend, is still observing the human pact. He has not gone over to the devil, and therefore there is no fear of treachery or conspiracy.

Soma, Dionysos, Attis, Aphrodite, the whole pantheon of so-called orgiastic divinities, represent, therefore, the absolute need of early man to create a divine symbol, whose divine power consisted in the fact that it could hold the dark, archaic tendency from its renegade path, and bring it within the sovereignty of the human communion. Thus

the real stroke of genius which came to the gods in that north-eastern quarter when the titans had pressed them against the wall, was to make Soma king. By this act of giving royal honours to the very thing which possessed daemonic powers the daemon was transformed into a god. Psychologically, it was the discovery that, by raising the idea of communion, relatedness, the human pact to the highest possible value, those forces of the unconscious which held for man the greatest danger were transformed into the safeguarding power of divinity. Thus also in historical times predatory, unscrupulous, undisciplined, savage chieftains and clans were transformed under the aegis of the same divine symbol into disciplined subjects of the king.

We are now in a position to understand why Shakti without safeguards symbolizes the uncontrolled destructive energy of primordial nature, while Shakti under the safeguard of communion is the creative energy of life.

I have tried within the limits of a short paper to reconstruct for you the original psychological condition out of which the king-idea arose. I trust you will not charge me with attempting to formulate a psychological hypothesis that runs counter to the accepted anthropological conception of kingship, as presented in *Myth and Ritual*, and *The Labyrinth*. Anthropological research has been concerned with a more or less exhaustive account of the manner in which the divine function and nature of the king has been manifested in all its manifold character and world-wide distribution. The question I have attempted to answer is why the king-idea was identified with divinity. Psychology and anthropology ask different questions and, therefore, they must necessarily have different ways of approach. But they need not clash.

Hocart opens his second chapter on the "Divinity of Kings" with these words: "The earliest known religion is a

belief in the divinity of kings. I do not say that it is necessarily the most primitive, but in the earliest records known, man appears to us worshipping gods and their earthly representatives, namely, kings. We have no right, in the present state of our knowledge, to assert that the worship of gods preceded that of kings ; we do not know. Perhaps there never were any gods without kings, or kings without gods. When we have discovered the origin of divine kingship we shall know, but at present we only know that when history begins there are kings, the representatives of gods." When I read that paragraph I thought to myself, how can archaeological research ever discover the origin of divine kingship? Divinity is not a concrete object to be discovered. Originally it is always a psychological experience, the meaning of which could be recaptured only by the intuitive faculty which enables one to partake, in some measure, of past experiences that express a recurrent human necessity. Every reconstruction of historical moments which has conviction to our feeling, as well as to our reason, is actually achieved in this way.

As you have doubtless guessed, the reconstruction I have attempted tonight is also a condensation of a very great number of empirical observations gathered from patients' material, as well as from my own. As a medical psychologist I am, of course, vulnerable to the criticism that constant experience of pathological mental processes has warped my vision and, therefore, I see things in a queer light. But I must point out that battling with titans, or the act of mystical union with the god, or the flame of divine intoxication, are not the ingredients of normal experience, and that only those minds which at certain crises have been carried over the line that separates reason from unreason, can give us a first-hand account of what these irrational experiences signify. Anyone who has known in his own life the well-nigh irresistible force of a daemonic complex, and has

learnt that by bringing this daemonic influence under the sovereignty of human relatedness it has become transformed into a spiritual power of undeniable efficacy, will appreciate what divine kingship means as a psychological reality. But even in the realm of so-called normal psychology, the releasing effect of confession (and confession is precisely the sharing of something that wants to be withheld) is apparent not only in the Oxford groups, or under the aegis of the Catholic Church, the historical *magna mater*, but also in the intimate sphere of personal relationship. I have observed a profound and enduring transformation of a man's basic attitude to life, result directly from confessing to myself and to his wife an experience which had cut him off from human acceptance with an unbearable sense of guilt. Anyone, indeed, who has developed a fair measure of psychological objectivity can make the experiment in himself of contrasting those facts of his experience which he has communicated to, or shared with, another mind with those facts he has never been able to impart. He will observe that all those contents that come within the sphere of relatedness have a warmer and livelier complexion than those that have been withheld; and moreover there will be noticeable a certain apprehension of danger or anxiety clinging to this secret shadow-world of the psyche.

If these facts are true of individual moral, are we not also entitled to suppose that the moral of a tribe or a people is subject to the same conditions? We also know from our own experience that anything which can undermine our moral can also prejudice the effective performance of the tasks upon which our existence depends. Hence the need to create a king; namely, a symbolical representative of the ruling principle: that value which cannot be overthrown by daemonic influences from the shadow-world of the unconscious. This is a need that must be recognized as vital for all mankind.

From the psychological point of view, then, the symbol of the divine king is an archetype which has been created in the basic psychic structure as an enduring answer to a vital human need. It is a psychic heirloom handed down in the continuity of the psychic process, and has its origin in man's greatest peril. How, then, are we to explain the fact that, according to the various observers mentioned by Elliot Smith, there are a large number of indigenous food-gathering tribes who have never conceived the necessity of creating or acquiring the king-symbol? The only answer I can suggest is that these peoples have remained contained within the psychic safeguard of the primal condition. So far as my enquiries have gone, it appears that these indigenous people have no collective rites of tribal initiation. I can speak from personal knowledge of certain primitive tribes of Californian Indians. Among the Achumawi, for instance, there is a form of solitary initiation in which the boy is advised to go up to a distant crater-lake and seek there his individual *tinihowi*. He is told by his father or guardian to dive into the lake at sundown, and it is impressed upon him that he is going to die. But if the *tinihowi* likes him, it will fetch him out and bring him back to life again. The *tinihowi* is usually an insect, a fly, a grasshopper, or a butterfly. But it can be a lynx, or even a stone. He has to learn its nature, its needs and its language. He must never bring it back to the village, nor must he ever speak of it to anyone. When he goes out to talk with it, he must fast and purify himself. It cannot stand the odour of meat, or refuse, or fornication, and his whole success as a brave, a runner, a shaman, indeed his whole future moral as a man, rests upon this magical relationship. Moreover, it is optional. Many men never achieve a *tinihowi*; and then they are just ordinary Indians, no one in particular.

If we find that this interesting primitive form is at all characteristic of the indigenous peoples, we might be able

to draw certain conclusions concerning the premises of the genuine primitive psychology. Judging from this instance, we can say that, for the Achumawi at least, the magical relation which holds the safeguard of superior moral, is not with the king or any tribal figures, but with a magically endowed natural object. Through his *tinihowi* he recreates the primal pact with nature, and feels the guarantee of a magical potency in so far as he maintains the pact; but if he breaks the pact, and loses his *tinihowi*, the magical potency departs. I can only bring this suggestion tentatively, because I have not sufficient evidence from other indigenous peoples to substantiate this conception. But the main thesis is not thereby affected. It is briefly this; human moral is the expression of an enduring safeguard. In the primitive, indigenous community man is still contained in the state of participation, or primal unity with nature: this is his safeguard. Whenever a relative degree of dissociation from, or opposition to this primal condition is reached, the need for a magical collective safeguard against the avenging power of nature becomes apparent. This need created the symbol of divine kingship. Through the fact that the king represented the whole continuity of tribal life and tradition, this symbol also safeguarded the continuity with the original source, which is the very essence of the pact with nature. In certain enduring cultures, as, for example, that of Egypt, the divine king or cultural hero is wedded to the mother or nature-goddess. The union of Isis and Osiris represents this dual allegiance; namely, to nature, as well as to culture. In certain other cultures, as we have seen in the Gilgamish epic, the cultural hero is a tyrannical, arrogant figure, who consistently spurns the feminine deity, and who attempts to break every natural instinctive bond in order to intensify the power of his principle. This headstrong, civilizing impetus, can produce a profound disunion in man between his cultural present

and his natural past. Then a new pact with nature has to be achieved, or she assumes the aspect of a vengeful, devouring monster.

If these reflexions seem to be rather specially opportune in the present phase of the civilizing experiment, it may be not unconnected with the fact that a very great number of my neurotic patients, who have somehow become prized away from their cultural background, manifest an overwhelming need to recover their natural birthright. They live in a civilization where thick layers of asphalt and concrete separate mankind from the fertile soil of the unconscious, and they simply have got to make their individual peace with nature, the original mother. This need to find again one's original being seems to be the basic theme of every dream and fantasy, and it often leads one far back on the path of man's ascent in order to recover the jewel that was neglected and left behind. I have come, therefore, to view the historical sequence of culture from this angle, and although the idea of the divine king has decayed in modern society to a more or less stereotyped convention, I find that the original *mana* of the king is all the more vigorous and alive in the individual unconscious. The king now becomes the symbol of the integrating individual principle, the concept of the impersonal ruler of the total subject, whose roots are strong in the inherited structure of the basic mind.

I trust this brief attempt at a psychological valuation of the king-idea will also contribute to the much-needed syncretism between psychology and anthropology.